

IN THE WILDERNESS A Shompen group on Great Nicobar Island

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SURVEY OF INDIA



> **“There is nothing in the judgment to show application of technical knowledge or of subject experts. The whole case has been dealt with as one of judicial review: whether or not a process was followed”**
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> **RITWICK DUTTA,** *Environmental lawyer*

lance system. Vijay Digambar Chafekar, a former additional director general of the Indian Coast Guard, believes India “hasn’t sufficiently leveraged” the strategic location of these islands due to competing priorities—the country’s security interests on the one hand and the untapped potential for tourism and trade on the other. “Considering the requirement of operational assets in this context for the Indian Navy and Coast Guard,” he says, “infrastructure development needs to be speeded up.”

Some experts argue that the underwraps defence establishment in GNI sits at the entrance of the Strait of Malacca, one of the world’s busiest chokepoints, and will give India logistical depth along major shipping arteries, enabling more rapid deployment to counterbalance China, besides serving as a major logistics node for its Quad partners. Admiral Arun Prakash, a former navy chief and the first Commander-in-Chief of the unified ANC, explains, “A&N’s strategic importance lies in the ability of island-based forces to monitor and, if required, interdict trade and energy routes across the Bay of Bengal. Herein lies China’ vulnerability—the sea lanes, connecting Shanghai, for example, with both the Red Sea and the Persian Gulf, are over 11,000 km long, and a full one-fifth or 2,000 km across the waters of the Bay of Bengal.” Yet sceptics, among them Abhijit Singh, question why a commercial port is needed to support a military mission, since INS Baaz already supports surveillance operations, and the Chinese navy has yet to challenge Indian interests in the region.

ECOLOGICAL WORRIES

Ecologists have flagged three broad areas of concern over the Great Nicobar project and the ecological damage it could inflict. According to government submissions before the NGT, the project would require clearing 130.75 sq. km of dense tropical forest. This would mean felling close to 711,000 trees. In his interview to INDIA TODAY, Bhupender Yadav claims that even after diversion, 82 per cent of the Great Nicobar area will remain under forest cover, in line with the National Forest Policy, 1988, which mandates that at least two-thirds of the area in hills and mountains remain under forests. Environmentalists call this claim misleading, saying that the project could fell as much as 15 per cent of the Great Nicobar’s total forests. Yadav also cites the compensatory afforestation planned in Haryana and Madhya Pradesh, “double in extent to the area being diverted”. But experts question the ecological logic of replacing ancient island rainforests with plantations in entirely different ecosystems.